

Impossible Murderers: Agatha Christie and the Community of Readers

Ina Rae Hark

Peter Hühn in his essay on "The Detective as Reader" notes that "in its elaborately contrived structures, the detective novel . . . presents a number of entangled writing-and-reading contests that ultimately only serve to demonstrate the superior power of *writing* (on the author's part), a power, moreover, that proves itself in two consecutive ways: in first protecting the stories against being read until the very end, and in finally producing a perfect as well as comprehensive reading" (459). In other words, classic detective stories, those whodunits or "clue-puzzles," in Stephen Knight's useful designation, initially offer a poststructuralist's dream of unreadable signification, only in the end to locate indeterminacy beyond the text in the deficient reading competency of all competing readers save that ideal decoder, the detective. As Hühn concludes, "this textual indeterminacy is . . . only a temporary illusion" because the central premise of the genre turns on the existence of determinate meanings (455).

Detective stories are then readerly texts in fancy dress, teasing us into believing ourselves Barthesian producers of textual meaning only to ask us to sit still while the detective's final explanation turns us into the most passive of consumers. Moreover, they are, according to Tzvetan Todorov, just as readerly as a group of texts, belonging to one of the genres of popular literature that, should they once be "properly described," would reveal the best novels as those about which one can find nothing to say (43).

The monumental and apparently undying consumability of Agatha Christie's detective novels has led many commentators to view her as a depressingly successful perfecter of the art of the readerly clue-puzzle. Here we find no characterization, only familiar types to be plugged into the exigencies of the plotting; no potentially destabilizing stylistic flourishes, only flat writing; no awareness of the operations of ideology, only panaceas for what Knight calls the "classic anxious bourgeois class" (133). Apparently substantiating such an

assessment are numerous passages from Christie's posthumously published *Autobiography* that feature such simplistic hierarchical binaries as the following: "We had not then begun to wallow in psychology. I was, like everyone else who wrote books or read them, *against* the criminal and *for* the innocent victim" (424).

Therefore, Christie's clue-puzzles should be the last place in which we should expect to find an indication of the tenuousness of the detective's claim to perceive the truth in matters of guilt or innocence, a recognition of the novel as mere textual battleground between author and reader. I would assert, however, that that is precisely what we do find there, that both intra- and extratextually Agatha Christie mysteries acknowledge themselves as not about crime-solving but about reading. Moreover, they posit the detective's ability to come up with determinate readings as an exception, a product of fantasy, precisely because the texts of guilt and innocence in the real world are so resolutely unreadable. And such unreadability as Christie texts, despite her many pronouncements to the contrary, demonstrate occurs because human guilt and innocence are thoroughly intermixed, rather than being in mutually exclusive binary opposition. If we attempt to read people like books in order to separate the murderous from the nonmurderous, we must fail, because in Christie's view no such creature as a person incapable of murder exists.

The most prominent clue to this unexpectedly sophisticated Christean textual philosophy reveals itself in the very textual operation Christie is most famous for: The dazzling surprises provoked by the revelation of her murderers' identities. A common thread among the particularly celebrated shockers is that they transgress the conventions for reading detective stories. Structurally, such stories have a tripartite division of characters: the investigators of a crime or crimes; the victims or intended victims; and everybody else, who thereby become the suspects, from which group the investigators eventually identify one or more criminals. Investigators and readers compete to reconcile readings of the circumstances of the crimes with readings of the behavior of the characters in order to effect the solution that matches suspect to guilt. Christie, however, consistently manipulates these categories so that the murderer emerges from the first or second group or has otherwise been exempted from membership in the group of suspects. The result, as Robert Barnard shrewdly observes, is not that Christie murderers are the least likely suspects but that they are among "the ones never suspected" (46).

We thus see crimes committed by the policemen investigating them (*Hercule Poirot's Christmas*, *Three Blind Mice*) or by amateur sleuths helping out the primary detective (*The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, *The Seven Dials Mystery*). Also linking the murderer to the investigating group is the frequently used device delineated by Gillian Gill: "The prime suspect—the person who stands to gain the most—has an apparently iron-clad alibi for a murder he or she in fact committed" (137). By accepting their alibis or otherwise vouching for them initially, Christie investigators habitually transform most likely suspects into

nonsuspects in the reader's mind. A staple ploy since her very first novel, *The Mysterious Affair at Styles*, this premature exoneration via legal system fiat, a kind of innocence by association, arguably has its most dazzling moment in *Witness for the Prosecution*, when the client the barrister protagonist has labored triumphantly to have acquitted, by discrediting the apparently vengeful spouse who testifies against him, turns out to be just as guilty as the prosecution has portrayed him. The wife, who had surmised his guilt and realized that a false alibi from a loving helpmeet would not be believed, had devised the whole complicated scheme in order to exonerate her faithless husband.

Christie's killers also frequently disguise themselves as victims, either reporting a near-miss in an attempt on their lives or convincing everyone that a murder victim has been mistakenly killed in their place. This strategy appeals particularly to her women murderers. In *Peril at End House*, for example, "Nick" Buckley must eliminate her cousin Maggie before it becomes known that it was to her cousin and not to herself that the deceased aviator Michael Seton was engaged and left an enormous fortune. She therefore arranges a series of apparent near-misses on her life and then kills Maggie in a way that suggests the bullet was intended for her. In *The Mirror Crack'd* Marina Gregg realizes at a cocktail party that Heather Badcock, a woman to whom she has been chatting, infected her years before with the German measles that caused her to bear a retarded child. She drops a fatal dose of tranquilizers into her own glass, arranges an exchange with Mrs. Badcock, and passes off the death as a bungled attempt on her own life.

In fact, Christie murderers are astoundingly proficient, no matter how byzantine their Rube Goldberg lethal schemes sometimes appear, and any claim that a bullet or poisoned drink "must have been meant for me" should immediately put readers on their guard. In the *tour de force* novel version of *And Then There Were None*, all the suspects—including the murderer—are also victims. The police arrive to find a house full of corpses, the vigilante jurist having faked his own murder, dispatched the remaining guests, and then committed suicide in a manner that duplicates the circumstances of his first "death."

Christie's transformation of all the suspects into victims in this novel is complemented by her delineation of all the suspects as murderers in *Murder on the Orient Express*. Both novels depend for their shock value on structuralist reader assumptions about the makeup of the pool of suspects. Even that master reader Poirot reports resisting his growing awareness of the extent of the conspiracy in *Orient Express*: "I said to myself: This is extraordinary—they cannot all be in it" (192).

The novel that made her reputation, *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, played not only on having the killer in the Dr. Watson role but also on reader assumptions that a first-person narrator could not turn out to be the culprit. The outcry concerning unfairness when the book first appeared in 1926 showed that the reading conventions for consumers of detective fiction excluded the unreliable narrator, who was becoming quite conventional himself in the "high" literature

of the time.

When we read Christie at her most distinctive, then, she confronts us with impossible murderers. They are impossible not because of their social class, race or gender, individual psychology, professed ideology, or prominence or peripheralness to the narration but because the ideal reader produced by the conventions of the genre is incapable of considering them as suspects at all. The solutions to her mysteries inevitably require the reader to employ Alexander's sword slash rather than patiently to unravel the Gordian knot of suspects, motives, and clues. The well-trained Christie reader comes to know that there is no such thing as an impossible murderer. Poirot cannot rule out anyone, and, as *Curtain* demonstrates, the reader cannot even rule out Poirot.

Curtain, in which Poirot closes his last case by murdering the murderer, holds a special position in Christie's ongoing dialogue with her community of readers and, perhaps because of this, provides the clearest exposition of her ideology and methodology. Written during World War II as an insurance policy for her family in case she were killed in the blitz, it remained in a safe, awaiting publication after her death. In the upshot, it was published in 1975, a year before her physical demise but as a consequence of the agreement between Christie's daughter Rosalind and her publisher Collins. It was clear after the disappointing 1972 *Postern of Fate* that Christie's days as a writer were over. The author is therefore both absent and present to her readers; the book is Poirot's last case to be published but his twelfth from last to be written. While the text when written could interact only with those produced prior to it, on its first availability to readers it already had an intertextual relationship with a number of books written subsequently that they were likely to have read previously.

Because of *Curtain's* dual temporal standing, Christie also had to criminalize and execute Poirot in a way that would not be inconsistent with his previous behavior or circumscribe any investigations she might pen while it remained "in the bank." And to maintain Poirot's popularity after both their deaths, Christie had to make this most impossible of her murderers at least as forgivable as the *Orient Express* passengers for whom he endorsed an alternative, exonerating clue-puzzle text that the authorities could substitute for his decoding of the actual conspiracy. To that end, Poirot kills only to stop a killer beyond the reach of the law, a procedure Christie tacitly approves not only in *Orient Express* but in *And Then There Were None* and *Cards on the Table*. She also has him stress the benefits of his crime to vulnerable innocents and, to cover all moral bases, put his heart medication out of reach so that God can render justice upon him for violating his lifelong "disapproval" of murder. Christie insists on the need for murderers to be arrested, in the sense of stopped, but cares little for having them arrested by law enforcement officials and paraded through public rituals of punishment.

Like Poirot and her other murderers who leave written confessions as suicide notes, Dr. Sheppard in *Roger Ackroyd* and the Judge in *And Then There Were*

None, the possibility of speaking from the grave seems to have made Christie especially forthcoming about her methods. *Curtain* reveals Christie's clear admission that her books are about texts, not crimes, and that her rationale for choosing murderers who affront readers' preconceptions is about reading mysteries, not about identifying criminals.

Gillian Gill astutely notes that "Whereas material clues tend very often to be red herrings in Agatha Christie's work, the textual clues are almost always important. . . . Textual clues . . . written words on paper, invoke the Great Detective's skill not as an orientalist or organic chemist or bibliophile, but *as a reader*, and the very nature of the genre allows the novel reader to compete" (49). In *Curtain* Poirot recognizes a serial killer behind a series of apparently unrelated murder trials that he has read about in the newspapers. The killer, when unmasked, proves to be quite beyond legal punishment because his murders are themselves textual. Conforming to a literary model, as a latter-day Iago, he reads his targets sufficiently well to manipulate them into committing the murder that, Poirot calmly asserts in his confession, incubates within us all: "Everyone is a potential murderer—in everyone there arises from time to time the *wish* to kill—though not the will to kill . . . X knew the exact word, the exact phrase, the intonation even to suggest and to bring cumulative pressure on a weak spot!" (216-17).

To stop X from writing any further murderous texts upon his random acquaintances, Poirot presents the case to Hastings in much the same way that author Christie offers her mysteries to readers. Having already identified the killer and, it turns out, the means by which he is to be stopped (just as Christie always wrote her unravel-the-plot solutions first), Poirot presents his friend with a written précis of each of the killer's past crimes, then sends him out to mingle with the suspects and observe them for signs of guilt. When Hastings has failed to identify the killer before Poirot's semisuicide, the detective leaves him two further textual clues, copies of *Othello* and St. John Ervine's *Clutie John*, both of which portray murderers who work in the same way that X does. Rightly suspecting that Hastings will still be in the dark without the typical Poirot exegesis, the detective has further arranged for a written solution of all the aspects of the case to be forwarded by his solicitors to his friend four months after his passing.

The novel Poirot writes for Hastings and that Hastings recopies for us is a semi-puzzling, fair-play, not very Christie-like text. Stephen Norton, revealed as the Iago, is not a particularly obvious suspect, but he isn't one of the trademark "never suspected" either. Hastings in fact considers him as "perhaps less unlikely than anyone else" because he is so inconspicuous. The identity of the person Norton succeeds in turning murderous, after false starts with Colonel Lutrell and Hastings himself, is slightly more surprising in that happenstance finally makes a Christie murderer administer poison to someone other than the intended victim—with the mistakenly killed individual being none other than the aspiring killer herself. Barbara Franklin, wanting to rid herself of her scientist-

husband, poisons his coffee in a way that will make it look as if his experimentation with alkaloids has proven fatal. Because Hastings revolves the bookcase upon which the couple's cups are placed, however, Barbara unwittingly drinks and dies from the poison she had meant for Dr. Franklin.

At the same time, however, Poirot is planting oblique clues for both Hastings and the reader as to the fact that a simultaneous and archetypal Poirot-Christie plot is unfolding. When Poirot announces to Hastings at the beginning of the novel his certainty that a murder will occur, he is speaking of his own scheme to execute Norton, the only way he can fulfill "my work in life to save the innocent" in the case of a catalytic killer immune to either remorse or legal punishment. While, on the one hand, veteran Christie readers might easily surmise that Poirot is the ultimate impossible murderer and that, should he kill, it would be under just such a set of circumstances, they would also quite likely attribute all the deaths and near-misses in *Curtain* to the mysterious X and overlook as completely as does Hastings the status of one victim as Poirot's target instead.¹

Aware that reflexive structures for reading Christie might simply supplant those for reading mystery novels in general that her impossible murderers are meant to dislodge, the author here and elsewhere brazenly trots them into plain view, confident that she can misdirect us as handily as the purloiner of Poe's famous letter did the Paris police. (Perhaps her most daring act of nosethumbing was to create another first-person-narrating killer in *Endless Night* despite her notoriety for using the device in *Roger Ackroyd*.) Conversely, the insisted-upon *déjà vu* of *Curtain*, as Hastings and Poirot return to Styles, the location of their first case—"I have done this before," Hastings muses—with Poirot limping from age as he had previously limped from a Great War injury, begs us to look for intertextual clues derived from *The Mysterious Affair at Styles*. However, the crimes and criminals in the two novels are, in fact, totally unrelated. The rhyming of the limp occurs rather because Poirot's scheme to execute Norton only succeeds because Norton also is lame; and lameness, in the *Curtain* context alone, is the signifier that unites the dispenser of justice and his prey.

Christie is at pains to make us distrust structuralist readings, not because she regards the concept of deep structures as false but because she sees all such structures collapsing into one: Every human text is a potential murder mystery. A truly proficient deep reader could only come to the *Orient Express* conclusion: They're all in it, and I'm one of them. Despite her carefully calculated persona as the shy, inarticulate Devonshire housewife, a pietistic Christian who turned out annual sanguinary best-sellers, much in the way her neighbors cultivated prize roses for the yearly garden-club show, Christie had as baleful a view of the potential depravity of Everyman as we find, for instance, in the films of Alfred Hitchcock.

The Hitchcockian idea of transference of guilt may, in fact, help explain two other Christie predilections: her insistence that identifying murderers has value primarily in protecting the innocent and her lack of concern about murderers

being brought to justice as long as the first objective has been accomplished. Because we are all potentially murderous and likely to be read as such, it is important to arrest such reading operations through conclusive identifications of those who have actually behaved murderously, not just who might have. At the same time, the metaphysical complicity of all persons in such behavior renders public preening on the disposition of offenders a hollow exercise. Thus, Miss Marple gives her blessing to Jason Rudd's tampering with his tormented, murderous wife Marina's medication in order to put her out of her misery; and Poirot says of Nick Buckley's likely drug overdose-suicide: "It is the best way. Better than the hangman's rope. But pst! we must not say so before M. Vyse who is all law and order" (176).

Christie insists that the failure to arrive at conclusive readings of human behavior (as opposed to human intentionality), all too common in quotidian reality, can cause significant and persistent harm. An impulse to fashion her texts as privileged spaces in which such harm may be corrected informs her retrospective cases like *Five Little Pigs* or *Ordeal by Innocence*, where so much effort goes into revising the misreadings of falsely convicted killers, even though they are long dead. Poirot's identification of Iago-X provides this collateral benefit as well. The much-criticized superficiality of Christie, in fact, merely acknowledges that sorting out the tangle of signifiers produced by an incident is the one reading operation having any pragmatic social utility.

Therefore, only on the behavioral level does Christie endorse structuralist readings, as in Miss Marple's solving crimes by having suspects' actions remind her of analogous ones, demonstrated by village acquaintances in her past. Furthermore, she is quite aware that those without Miss Marple's special talents will misread such recurring structures much more frequently than they will decode them, so that the interpretive strategies of the St. Mary Mead sleuth have little widespread applicability.

The ability of Christie's detective super-readers to sort surface innocence from surface guilt does not then indicate any simpleminded assumption on the author's part that such distinctions will eventually emerge in all the puzzles of life. She offers their solutions as a fantasy consolation to her readers because she knows that they are a fantasy, as she knows the considerable pain that life's generally remaining intractably unreadable causes. After all, for eleven days in December 1926, from the time she abandoned her wrecked car until she was discovered living in a Harrogate spa under the name of her husband's mistress, Agatha Christie participated in events that have resisted conclusive interpretation even by herself, if her claim of amnesia is to be believed. A generator of various textual explanations by tabloid reporters, friends and family, biographers, and Kathleen Tynan in her charming novel *Agatha* (filmed by Michael Apted with Vanessa Redgrave and Dustin Hoffman), the incident is represented only by its absence in the *Autobiography*. And fifteen years after

Christie's death, no letter from anyone's solicitor has arrived to turn that mass of indeterminate signifiers into a comfortably readerly text.

NOTE

1. When, after having read all of Christie's full-length mystery novels, I heard that she had written Poirot's last case and that it was soon to be published, I wagered with some fellow Christie aficionados that in it, Poirot would commit murder in order to eliminate someone the law couldn't touch and to protect innocents from coming to any further harm—and that he would then commit suicide. Nevertheless, when I actually read *Curtain*, which followed the pattern I had predicted to the letter, I was sure up to the point that Poirot's missive to Hastings arrived that I had been mistaken.

REFERENCES

- Barnard, Robert. *A Talent to Deceive: An Appreciation of Agatha Christie*. London: Collins, 1980.
- Christie, Agatha. *An Autobiography*. New York: Dodd, Mead, 1977.
- _____. *Curtain*. New York: Dodd, Mead, 1975.
- _____. *Murder on the Orient Express*. 1934. New York: Pocket Books, 1969. Reprint.
- _____. *Peril at End House*. 1932. New York: Pocket Books, 1971. Reprint.
- Gill, Gillian. *Agatha Christie: The Woman and Her Mysteries*. New York: Macmillan, 1990.
- Hühn, Peter. "The Detective as Reader: Narrativity and Reading Concepts in Detective Fiction." *Modern Fiction Studies* 33 (1987).
- Knight, Stephen. *Form and Ideology in Crime Fiction*. London: Macmillan, 1980.
- Todorov, Tzvetan. "The Typology of Detective Fiction." In *The Poetics of Prose*, translated by Richard Howard. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1977.